

Career Readiness Perception Gap: Findings and Recommendations

Career Readiness Survey Analysis
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This report summarizes findings from a dual perspective career readiness survey conducted across the university. Approximately 840 students rated their own readiness on 22 competencies spanning seven NACE aligned dimensions (Career and Self Development, Communication, Critical Thinking, Leadership, Professionalism, Teamwork, and Technology), using a one to four scale. Roughly 1,000 workplace supervisors rated the same students on the identical competencies. Comparing the two perspectives reveals a consistent perception gap with clear implications for career development programming.

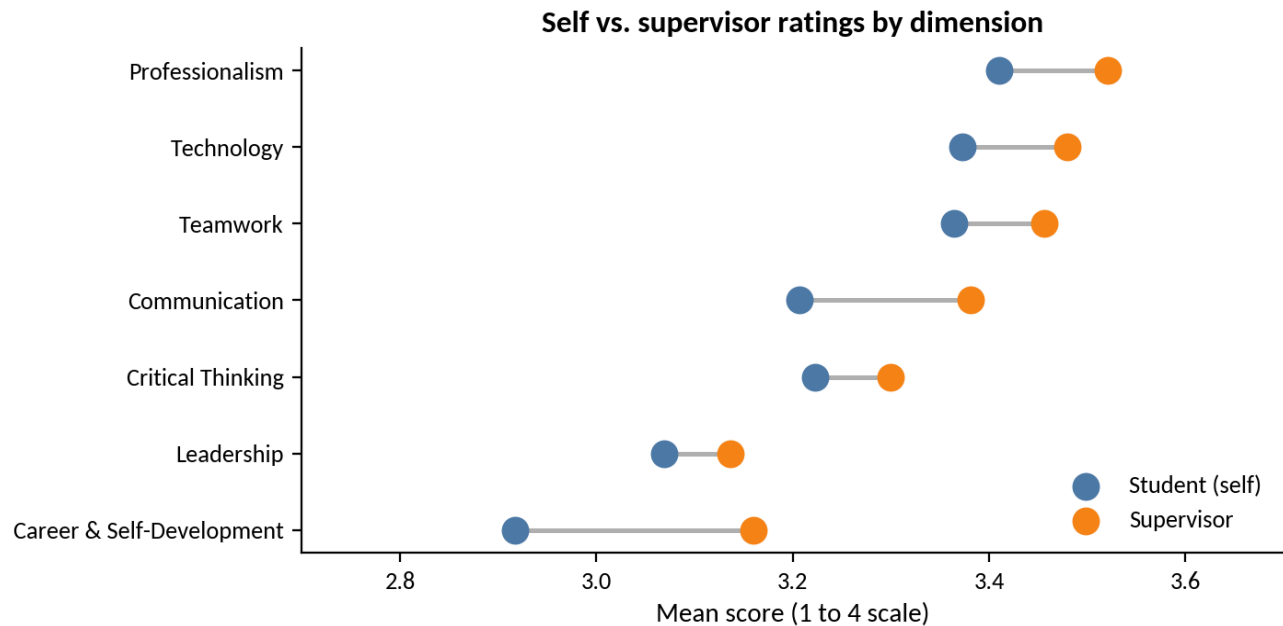


Figure 1. Mean self ratings (blue) and supervisor ratings (orange) for each career readiness dimension. Professionalism ranks highest for both groups; Career and Self Development ranks lowest for students, while Leadership ranks lowest for supervisors.

Every dimension follows the same pattern: supervisors rate students higher than students rate themselves. This is not overconfidence, it is a confidence gap, the opposite of what conventional wisdom about self assessment typically predicts.

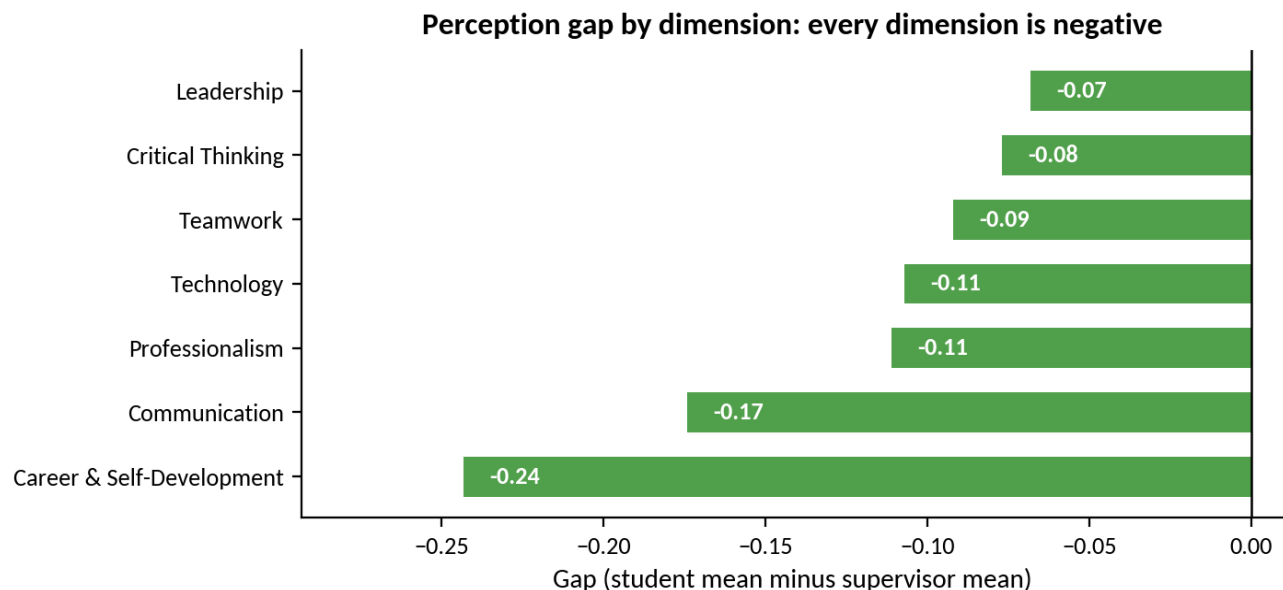


Figure 2. The gap (student mean minus supervisor mean) for each dimension, sorted from smallest to largest in magnitude. All seven values are negative. Career and Self Development shows the largest gap, while Leadership shows the smallest.

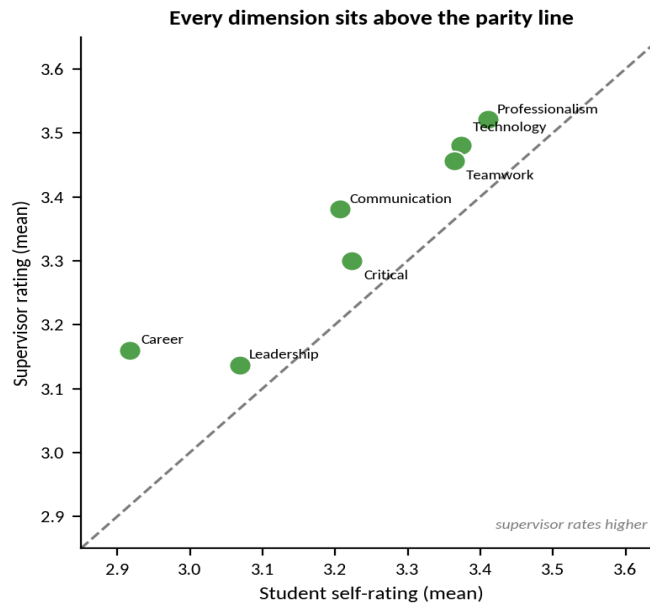


Figure 3. Student self ratings plotted against supervisor ratings for each dimension. Every point falls above the diagonal reference line, confirming that supervisors rated students higher on every single dimension with no exceptions.

Table 1. Complete perception gap results by dimension.

Dimension	Student	Supervisor	Gap	Cohen's d
Career & Self-Development	2.92	3.16	-0.24	-0.29
Communication	3.21	3.38	-0.17	-0.22
Professionalism	3.41	3.52	-0.11	-0.13
Technology	3.37	3.48	-0.11	-0.13
Teamwork	3.36	3.46	-0.09	-0.12
Critical Thinking	3.22	3.30	-0.08	-0.09
Leadership	3.07	3.14	-0.07	-0.08

Recommendations

- Build skills where supervisors see the greatest need: Leadership is the lowest rated dimension by external assessment (3.14 of 4) and should be the priority for skill building, such as facilitation and delegation practice within experiential placements.
- Build confidence where students under-claim ability: Career and Self Development combines the lowest self rating and the largest under-estimate, calling for structured self-assessment checkpoints and strengths-based reflection.
- Close the calibration loop with structured supervisor feedback: since under-rating is consistent across all seven dimensions, students likely rarely hear how supervisors actually rate them. A brief mid-placement feedback conversation could meaningfully close this gap over time.
- Track this survey across multiple terms: repeating the assessment will show whether the gap narrows as feedback practices take hold, turning a single snapshot into an ongoing measure of program impact.

Methodology and Caveats

This analysis compares two separate respondent pools, students and supervisors, not matched individual pairs, so findings describe group level patterns rather than individual miscalibration. All relationships are cross sectional and associative, not causal. Effect sizes (Cohen's d) are small for every dimension, below the conventional medium effect threshold of 0.5, meaning these gaps are best treated as monitor items rather than urgent concerns, though their complete directional consistency across all seven dimensions is a meaningful pattern in its own right.